TELCO’s marketing wing too was strengthened. Ratan infused fresh blood in the system. ‘He said, “Go and meet people who have no automobile background,”’ says Dube. His advice was to recruit youngsters in the sales and servicing wing. Their average age was just twenty-nine. They ‘had fire in their bellies’, according to Dube, and helped create India’s first car brand. Ratan would often come and talk to the people in the factory too, personally motivating them.

As Ratan declared during the 1995 AGM, the various divisions were created for TELCO to ‘function as a “seamless organization”, where individual compartments and all internal boundaries within the organization [would] disappear, in order to make the company more responsive to market and customer needs’. He would always ‘start with a value proposition for the customer’, says Shailesh Chandra, president, electric mobility and corporate strategy, Tata Motors.

Amongst the reforms he ushered in the company particular importance was assigned to strengthening R&D in the vehicle manufacturer. The transformation he brought about through this was particularly impactful. He drove home the point that continuing to manufacture the same models year after year would not render TELCO an industry leader. Ratan emphasized that ‘TELCO needed to be able to design and develop products that were on par with the best in the industry and then sharpen its winning edge’, says T.N. Umamaheshwaran, vice president and head of digital product development and strategic business planning, Tata Motors. Achieving this meant mastering the ‘new age digital development processes well before it (TELCO) could introduce them in the actual development of a product’, he recalls.

Within a year of taking over the company, Ratan established Tata Technologies as a part of Tata Motors to help in design and engineering. ‘It made a significant contribution’ to the company by undertaking several design tasks for TELCO, says Girish Wagh. The company also grew by acquiring related entities in Europe. In 1994, Tata Technologies was hived off as a separate business unit headquartered in Europe and has since been assisting Tata Motors in its various projects, including the Nano. It grew into a company with a $421 million turnover (as of 2019).

Before Ratan became chairman, TELCO’s car designs were made on drawing boards using slide rulers. He leapfrogged the company from drawing boards directly to 3D computer-aided design (CAD) and